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THE CLEAN-UP ACT

From gutkha to restaurants, Mundhe expands the enforcement net

- In May, Mundhe began by cracking down on the illegal sale and consumption of gutkha
- The enforcement then widened to restaurants, the milk industry and dairies, followed by action against the sale of junk food in schools
- By end-July, about **3,100** food business operators had been inspected (the number may have crossed **10,000** by end-August, say officials), more than **750** improvement notices had been issued and **165** licences suspended

"I am working without a vested interest...my only vested interest is to serve the people of Maharashtra"

— TUKARAM MUNDHE
Commissioner, FDA, Maharashtra





The FDA commissioner has become a viral sensation on social media, the joke being a 'Tukaram Mundhe approval badge' carries more heft for any eatery than a Michelin star

AT GROUND ZERO

The FDA's raids have exposed the dirty underbelly of the food industry's kitchens—from infestations of flies and cockroaches and substandard or poor-quality products to poor hygiene, including fungus-infested vegetables and fruits and pickles stored in a drum lined with fungus on the inside. A popular ice-cream joint in South Mumbai was found to be teeming with rats, and the owners are said to have told bewildered food safety officers that they were their "pets"!

Noor Mohammadi, which was started 103 years ago as a modest *'bhatiyarkhana'* (where food is prepared for travellers) by Abdul Kareem, a migrant from Sambhal in Uttar Pradesh, was among the establishments whose FSSAI licence was suspended for allegedly operating in unhygienic conditions. The restaurant, once patronised by the likes of Saadat Hasan Manto, Dilip Kumar, M.F. Husain, underworld don and smuggler Haji Mastan, and even poor migrants, was shut for 21 days. "I had to completely remake the kitchen," says Khalid Hakim, the founder's grandson.